

DISCUSSION ACTIVITY 1

Questions 1–5:

For each of the following arguments, identify the premises and the conclusion and place the argument in standard form. Clearly write down the propositions that are premises and which are conclusions.

Question 1

It is right that men should value the soul rather than the body; for perfection of soul corrects the inferiority of the body, but physical strength without intelligence does nothing to improve the mind.
[Democritus]

Question 2

The table, which we see, seems to diminish, as we remove farther from it; but the real table, which exists independent of us, suffers no alteration; it was, therefore, nothing but its image, which was present to the mind. [Hume]

Question 3

There cannot be any emptiness; for what is empty is nothing, and what is nothing cannot be.
[Melissus]

Question 4

We see that things which lack intelligence, such as natural bodies, act for an end, and this is evident from their acting always or nearly always, in the same way, so as to obtain the best result... . Now whatever lacks intelligence cannot move towards an end, unless it be directed by some being endowed with knowledge and intelligence; as the arrow is shot to its mark by the archer. Therefore, some intelligence exists by whom all natural things are directed to their end; and this being we call God. [Thomas Aquinas]

Question 5

In the beginning man was born from creatures of a different kind; because other creatures are soon self-supporting, but man alone needs prolonged nursing. For this reason he would not have survived if this had been his original form. [Anaximenes]

Questions 6–15:

Determine whether each of the following contains an *Ad Baculum* argument and/or *Ad Hominem* argument. If yes, determine further whether it involves a corresponding fallacy. Answer Y (Yes) or N (No) in the corresponding blanks. In addition, *explain* why you think so.

Question 6

Chairman of the Board: "All those thinking my arguments for the opening of a new department do not deserve careful attention, signify by saying, 'I resign.'"

Ad Baculum argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Baculum fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Question 7

Candidate Logan's proposal about zoning is ridiculous. He was caught cheating on his taxes in 2001.

Ad Baculum argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Baculum fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Question 8

The Department of Transportation may want to reconsider the speed limit proposals on interstate highways for the simple reason that if they do not, their departmental budget will be cut by 25%.

Ad Baculum argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Baculum fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Question 9

What would Olivia know about fixing cars? She is a woman.

Ad Baculum argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Baculum fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Question 10

I think that we should reject what Father Jones has to say about the ethical issues of abortion because he is a Catholic priest. After all, Father Jones is required to hold such views.

Ad Baculum argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Baculum fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Question 11

On October 10, 1971, US Secretary of State William P. Rogers cautioned foreign ministers that Congress might force the United States reduce its financial contributions to the United Nations if Nationalist China (Taiwan) is expelled.

Ad Baculum argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Baculum fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Question 12

Greenpeace environmentalists opposed nuclear testing in Alaska arguing that the large underground nuclear tests at Amchitka Island in the early 1970's had the possible results of earthquakes, tsunamis, and radioactive contamination.

Ad Baculum argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Baculum fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Question 13

What makes you so smart and all-knowing that you deny Einstein's theory of relativity? You haven't even finished school.

Ad Baculum argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Baculum fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Question 14

You're a German, so there is no reason to think that your opinion about what qualifies as good Chinese cinema has any merit.

Ad Baculum argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Baculum fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Question 15

Study hard or you will not get high grades in this course!

Ad Baculum argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Baculum fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem argument? [Yes or No?]

Ad Hominem fallacy? [Yes or No?]

Question 16:

As a group, find *at least one* real life example of an *Ad Baculum* argument and *at least one* real life example of an *Ad Hominem* argument, and explain whether they are fallacious or non-fallacious.

NOTE: Don't copy and paste the examples from the internet fallacy resources! Rather look for them in real life advertisements, news (online sources are ok), recent political debates, books, etc. In each case add a clear reference to the source or attach a picture (of an advertisement, etc.) Don't use the examples from the internet resources on the fallacies because (1) they are all limited in number and easy to track, (2) very often (and, I would say, most of them) are incorrect – very rarely people make a correct distinction between fallacious and non-fallacious arguments while our textbook is very precise about it.